



Photographs by MOHAMMED JAFFER



SANJAY SANGHOEE

Laid off at the hedge fund, Ramius Capital Group

An MBA from Columbia University, Sanghoee has written a novel *Merger*. He has now decided to spend his time working on his second book while taking on consultancy jobs. Is yet to tell his family that he has lost his job.

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For Indian immigrants who came to this country to better their futures, life seems to be in limbo as stock portfolios dwindle, pink slips proliferate and those still with a job face pay cuts. For Indian-Americans who were the kings of Wall Street and privileged yuppies, there's a new reality out there. To work with blue chip companies like Lehman Brothers, AIG and General Motors was a badge of honour but now it's like ashes in the mouth. Art investments are a capital loss and big homes have become an albatross. Sanjay Sanghoee, who was laid off at the hedge fund, Ramius Capital Group, describes the shell-shocked atmosphere in the early days of the economic crisis: "One thing after another was happening—Bear Stearns, Lehman, AIG—nobody knew where this was going to go, no one was prepared for it." He recalls the chaotic times, with networking sessions and job sites crowded with people looking for consultancy assignments and any jobs in a shrinking market and hiring freezes. "I reached out to the Indian community on Wall Street but found quickly that lots of Indians were getting laid off."

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and with a novel, *Merger*, to his credit, Sanghoee decided to work on his second novel while taking up consultancy jobs. He finds that many Indian-Americans are hampered in retooling themselves for the new times: "Being Indian, you're so integrated with your job and if you don't have employment, people freak out." Sanghoee has still not told his family that he's lost his six-figure job. He adds that some Indian-Americans, who are in senior positions in private equity and hedge fund sectors, have not done too badly as hedge funds have downsized or regrouped to become distress funds to invest in distress securities.

In the tight job market, some have even been looking to India for employment. When Bear Stearns collapsed, Rohinton Dadina was the managing director of its International Debt Capital Markets Group. With 20 years of experience in emerging market debt transactions, he really loved his job. He says, "Our group was doing well but the firm fell apart. It was a big shock and it took a long time to sink in." With employment hard to come by, he was prepared to relocate to India, as some of his other friends, but the job market in India was not too promising. He finally found a job in the US and he is now managing director and senior credit officer at Minlam Asset Management LLC.

The grim job market has taken its toll on Indian students, many of whom had hoped to stay on and work in the US. Kamal Kishnani of Jaipur has just completed his MBA at Pace University but has been unable to find a job. With the clock ticking, he will soon have to leave. He says there are at least 500-600 such students who may have to return after completing their degrees. Perhaps the biggest impact has been on H-1B visa holders. Vivek Wadhwa, the lead researcher on a newly-released study, America's Loss is the World's Gain, conducted a two-year study of 1,203 Indian and Chinese subjects who had studied or worked in the US for a year or more before returning home. The findings show that professional opportunities back home along with quality of life issues were the

stock market and in the 401K—retirement investments." He estimates that business in Jackson Heights is down by 35 to 40 per cent, and things may not pick up for a while.

Across the street, India Sari Palace brims over with multicoloured fabrics and fancy outfits, but there are few buyers. Ramesh Navani, the manager, says that even though the American economy has been in a downturn for several months, business was fine till Diwali, after which there was a sudden drop: "Now we can feel a severe effect and we too are victims of the economy. People are holding back because they